NOTICE / STUDENT POLICY PROPOSAL

NO GRADES. FIRST YEAR.





Concept illustrations of the Rochester campus and student learning; not documentary photographs.

THE PROPOSAL

Replace A–F grades in the first year with Pass / No Pass and written feedback. Keep clear learning standards, academic support, and private progress reports. Return to normal grades in year two.

01 **LEARN**
Try unfamiliar subjects

02 **GET FEEDBACK**
Revise and improve

03 **MOVE FORWARD**
Grades return in year two

WHAT WE GAIN

- Less pressure to chase GPA
- More freedom to explore classes
- A first year focused on growth

WHAT WE RISK

- Weaker grade-based incentives
- Less GPA data for internships
- More time spent writing feedback

THE ECONOMIC TRADE-OFF

The visible cost is more faculty time spent giving feedback. A hidden cost is weaker grade signals for employers and future programs. The benefit is better learning and a stronger identity. Rochester would resist the pressure to rank students from day one.

THE QUESTION

Should college reward learning or rank students?

Cultural moat: defend exploration over competition, even when feedback takes more time.

Counterfactual: without the policy, first-year grades remain a strong incentive and sorting tool.

ECON 238 | Proposed policy only — not a current University of Rochester rule